MISSION 01 · EARN

Let's earn some money!



Build a grown-up's monthly money plan.
Pick a job. Make a plan. You're in charge!

My name _____ **Date** _____

1 Pick a real career

U.S. median pay, 2025—not a starting salary. Assume 40 paid hours each week.



Graphic designer
Make colorful designs
$30.27 / hour



Veterinary technician
Help care for animals
$22.78 / hour



Software developer
Build apps and programs
$65.38 / hour

2 Find your monthly income

Gross pay is money earned before taxes. Take-home pay is what you can budget.

Work rule: 40 hours/week × 52 weeks/year ÷ 12 months

1. Weekly gross pay	_____ × 40 =	_____
2. Average monthly gross	_____ × 52 ÷ 12 =	_____
3. Estimated monthly taxes Federal + NC + Social Security/Medicare		_____

Monthly take-home pay

Monthly gross – estimated taxes. Use this for your budget. _____

Our example household

One adult renting in Raleigh, North Carolina. Pay uses 2025 national medians; tax rules and local cost references are from 2026. Expenses are realistic planning estimates, not exact bills. A month is not always four weeks.

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

What is your gross pay for a whole year?

_____

MISSION 02 · NEEDS

A home. Food. A way to go.

A **need** helps you live and stay well, like food and a safe home. Choose a home and travel for one adult. All costs below are monthly.

1 Choose your home

Raleigh rental scenarios—not mortgages or measured averages by home type.



Cozy apartment
1 bedroom · 750 sq ft



Townhouse
2 bedrooms · 1,200 sq ft



House
3 bedrooms · 1,800 sq ft

Estimated rent and utility bills · per month

Monthly bill	Apartment	Townhouse	House
Rent only	**$1,300**	**$1,900**	**$2,300**
Electricity Includes heating & cooling	$105	$150	$210
Water & sewer	$60	$75	$80
Trash	$20	$25	$30
Utilities only Rent is NOT included	**$185**	**$250**	**$320**

Estimates for all-electric homes. Bigger spaces, weather, water use, and the lease change bills. Internet is budgeted separately. How we estimated these bills.

2 Choose how to travel

Choose a monthly travel plan. The car amount includes more than its payment.



Walk or bike
$20 / month



Public Transit
$80 / month



Used car
$780 / month

Transport bills · per month

Monthly bill	Walk / bike	Public Transit	Used car
Car payment	N/A	N/A	$350
Gas / fuel	N/A	N/A	$150
Vehicle insurance	N/A	N/A	$160
Public Transit pass	N/A	$80	N/A
Maintenance & repairs	$20	N/A	$100
Registration & vehicle taxes	N/A	N/A	$20
Total monthly transport	**$20**	**$80**	**$780**

N/A means no bill for that option. Public Transit uses GoTriangle's $80 adult monthly fare cap. Car costs are estimates for about 1,000 miles/month; maintenance and yearly registration are monthly set-asides. Costs & assumptions.

MISSION 02 · ADD YOUR NEEDS

Your monthly essentials.

Use the home and travel choices on the previous page. Keep rent and utilities separate, then add every monthly need.

Rent only	_____
Utilities only	_____
Transportation	_____
Groceries	$400
Internet $70 + phone $55	$125
Health costs	$280
Clothing & household items $150 + renters insurance $20	$170
Total monthly needs	_____

Why did you choose this home or way to travel?

MISSION 03 · SAVE & SPEND

Save first. Then a little fun!

Saving means keeping money for later. A **want** is something you enjoy but can live without. Plan your savings before your wants.

1 Give your savings a goal

It can be something special—or money for a surprise need.

I'm saving for...	Money I will save this month
_____	$ _____

2 Choose a little fun

Pick a monthly fun allowance—not the price of one item.

Free outings	Treats & streaming	Movies & hobbies
$0 / month	$50 / month	$100 / month

Money for savings	_____
Money for my want	_____
Savings + wants	_____

One need and one want in my own life:

_____

_____

_____

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

If you save the same amount for 3 months, how much will you have?

_____

MISSION 04 · CHECK

Make your money fit.

A **budget** is a plan for your money. Let's see if your monthly take-home pay covers your needs, wants, and savings.

Monthly take-home pay	_____
Money for needs	_____
Money for savings	_____
Money for wants	_____
Money I planned	_____

Take-home pay – money planned =

Money left over _____

If your answer is below $0, change a choice. If it is $0 or more, your monthly plan fits!

1. **Does your plan fit? What could you change?**

2. **Which need or want costs the most in your plan?**

3. **Surprise! You need to replace something that broke. It costs $150. Can your leftover money cover it? What else could you do?**

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

What percent of your income did you save?

(Monthly savings ÷ monthly take-home pay) × 100. A calculator can help.

_____

Name: _____ You practiced earning, choosing, saving, and planning. That's a money skill!